

Speaker 1 [00:00:03] Start.

Speaker 2 [00:00:04] From the beginning. The recording has just started for me.

Speaker 1 [00:00:08] So, I'm going to ask some socio-demographic questions first, then we can really start. OK? How old are you?

Speaker 2 [00:00:23] [26-30].

Speaker 1 And how long have you and your husband been together?

Speaker 2 [00:00:34] Almost [6-10] years.

Speaker 1 Do you have children? And who you live with.

Speaker 2 [00:00:41] I live with him and my pets.

Speaker 1 [00:00:45] What pets do you have, besides the garden?

Speaker 2 [00:00:47] I have a dog named [Name] (Name).

Speaker 1 [00:00:51] How cute! My cat is named [Name] (Name) and I wanted to share that.

Speaker 2 [00:00:57] I got lost, and she brought a bed.

Speaker 1 [00:01:01] Meow, meow. Yes, because here it's your main source of income. What is your current profession?

Speaker 2 [00:01:11] My main source of income. I don't have income. I get an allowance from my father and my husband supports our expenses.

Speaker 1 [00:01:21] And this student has this. I also have the same thing, but it's like my father's pension. And then [Name], who now works. That's why I resigned. And how do you want us to refer to your husband? Can it be like [Partner's Name], [Partner's Name]?

Speaker 2 [00:01:40] It can be [Partner's Name].

Speaker 1 [00:01:43] And now? To really start, I'd like you to tell me your love story. How was it from the beginning? How did you meet, the proposal, that sort of thing.

Speaker 2 [00:01:55] So, we met at work. He worked at [Company] and so did I, and I was assigned there. I passed a program and they placed me at the unit where he worked, and he was designated to be my [position]. I was to be trained with him. He would be my... there was a name, anyway, I was to be trained with him. The person was my... anyway. I was dating when we met, and he was engaged. And then, since we spent a lot of time together, working together, social life and work didn't separate very well. We started working together in [Month] and we

started seeing each other in [Month]. We were both in worn-out relationships and we started to notice this because of our closeness. We began to see that it didn't make sense to be with someone who didn't make us feel as good as we did with each other. Both of our relationships were long-distance. We started spending a lot of time together. One thing led to another, and we started seeing each other without detaching from our previous relationships, very politically incorrect. We know that. We started seeing each other at the beginning of [Month], and we thought it was going to be a casual thing. By [Event], we were deeply involved, like saying 'I love you'. In [Month], I moved. I used to live with my mom and commute back and forth. In [Month], I moved to [Municipality], where we worked. In [Month], he moved in with me. We had already ended our previous relationships definitively by then. Since then, we have lived together. At that time, I was working and everything. Then I got sick, and he supported me, which was the first barrier. Everything just fit very well. So, we say everything happened very fast, but it worked out well, and we've been together ever since.

Speaker 1 [00:05:24] It's not complicated, but it's sweet at the same time.

Speaker 2 [00:05:30] We think that despite the small pains along the way, hurting some people in the process, we know we are meant to be together, so it's all good.

Speaker 1 [00:05:43] She didn't know your story, but generally.

Speaker 2 [00:05:48] It's a story we love to tell. When we go out drinking at a bar, he sings, and I sing along.

Speaker 1 [00:05:57] It's really great to hear you tell it so excitedly now.

Speaker 2 [00:06:01] Because it's very funny. If he is extremely social, he sings it much better than I do.

Speaker 1 [00:06:09] Cool. I know. How would you compare your relationship with the relationships of your friends, based on what you know about them?

Speaker 2 [00:06:24] I didn't quite understand that last part of the question. How do I compare my romantic relationship with my friendships? Is that it?

Speaker 1 [00:06:32] No, your friends' romantic relationships. Like, do you compare your relationship to theirs? It might sound strange, but based on judgment.

Speaker 2 [00:06:43] I understand. I feel like I'm with my best friend, so my relationship feels like fifth grade, you know? When I look at my friends, people my age, it seems like they have more mature, and therefore somewhat more boring, relationships than mine. This is my judgment. I think my relationship, in terms of goofiness and great friendship, stands out. But at the same time, I feel our relationship is very mature compared to many others. This is not just about friends but also past relationships I've had. I think it's hard to separate this. We have a strong foundation in dialogue, allowing us to handle significant issues for us both individually and as a couple very openly. We don't argue when we're stressed; we wait for things to cool

down, understand each other first, and then address the external issues. We focus on our internal well-being, not just individually but for our relationship's health. In other relationships I've seen, people sometimes forget this maintenance part. I'm the kind of person who'd love to do couple's therapy even when not in crisis.

Speaker 1 [00:08:36] So, your relationship has higher quality than those of friends you know?

Speaker 2 [00:08:42] Yes, okay, I get it.

Speaker 1 [00:08:45] I have to use this term 'quality'; it might sound like a bad comparison, but it's not a value judgment.

Speaker 2 [00:08:51] Okay, yes.

Speaker 1 [00:08:53] Combining with a bit of what you said about previous relationships, have you had only one relationship before your husband? Or others as well?

Speaker 2 [00:09:04] I've had [1-5] serious boyfriends, one serious relationship and other things that weren't considered canonical relationships. Do you want me to touch on those too?

Speaker 1 [00:09:20] Yes, if you could focus on the quality of those relationships.

Speaker 2 [00:09:28] I think they improved in quality progressively, reflecting my own maturity. My first relationship became a strong friendship, and we didn't know how to manage that. We couldn't find strategies, so it lacked some quality aspects. My second relationship also lacked something. I don't think they failed; they worked well for the time they lasted. But none met all my internalized criteria for success, hence they didn't last. So, in terms of quality, I think it progressively increased.

Speaker 1 [00:10:32] And within this quality, there was wear, but not arguments, just time.

Speaker 2 [00:10:41] Routine over time, difficulty aligning expectations. That's what led to the end of my last relationship when I started seeing [Partner's Name]. So, no, it wasn't about arguments but perhaps immaturity as individuals, misaligned expectations, lack of dialogue, lack of openness, lack of clarity.

Speaker 1 [00:11:10] Now in general, not just you, how would you define high-quality and low-quality relationships? What aspects?

Speaker 2 [00:11:23] Perfect! Great. It's very clear to me because I've even taken it to therapy. A high-quality relationship needs respect for who each person is before being in a relationship, openness for dialogue, and aligned expectations. Respect, because I respect my husband for who he is, despite his flaws that sometimes bother me. Openness for dialogue because, without it, we go nowhere. It's important to be open to hear, even difficult feedback. Aligned expectations because we change over time. The mindset I had when I started with my husband isn't the same now. We need constant conversations to align where we, as individuals and as a

couple, want to go. Where do we want to be? What are our joint plans? Can we align our individual plans to achieve our goals together? All this through respect, dialogue. These are the three aspects that bring quality to a relationship. A lower quality relationship would have these aspects in smaller proportions or lack some of them.

Speaker 1 [00:13:43] I understand that low quality means lacking these, but if you could characterize low quality.

Speaker 2 [00:13:55] I think a main aspect that might lower relationship quality is always placing on the other the responsibility that is yours. We can resolve this through dialogue and self-understanding. So, maybe low self-awareness and therefore blaming the other instead of taking responsibility. This leads to issues like pride, guilt, judgments, accusations, that sort of thing.

Speaker 1 [00:14:54] Perfect. I understand the answers. For you, what's the most important thing in a relationship? Love, companionship, dialogue? What's the most important?

Speaker 2 [00:15:10] I say the greatest quality in my relationship is companionship. I think it brings a lot with it. So maybe companionship, partnership.

Speaker 1 [00:15:19] Why? Because you do everything together? Because you manage to...

Speaker 2 [00:15:24] Because of how our relationship was built, because he supported me through tough times, and then I did the same for him. Our choices, the way we've built our relationship over time. Nowadays, yes, because we live alone in a city without family, except for his work connections. So, maintaining the partnership is very important, even though we know maintaining individual activities and hobbies is also crucial. Despite knowing it's important, we do everything together. But I think due to our construction, how events happened, one thing led to another, we realize that partnership has always been renewed, reiterated, and it's a strong glue.

Speaker 1 [00:16:30] Yes, great. And now a philosophical question. Okay, I know. What does love mean? What is love?

Speaker 2 [00:16:40] Ah, I'll have to cheat because I agree a lot with bell hooks. I'll reproduce a bit of what she says in the book 'All About Love': love should be seen as a verb, not just a feeling floating in the air and remaining despite things. Love needs to be acted upon through various aspects: care, respect, dialogue, emotional responsibility, presence. These converge to maintain love. Love isn't a given, it's not magic. As it was built, it needs to be energetically and actively maintained.

Speaker 1 [00:18:04] So for you, love is extremely essential in a relationship. Some say love isn't enough. In line with your definition, paraphrasing bell hooks.

Speaker 2 [00:18:19] Feel free. You're paraphrasing well. Yes, I think it is. When people say it's not enough, they see it as something concrete and finite, compartmentalized. But when you see love in all aspects of daily life, as an action, it becomes enough.

Speaker 1 [00:18:52] How do you know he loves you? What does he do or say that makes you feel he loves you?

Speaker 2 [00:18:59] I feel protected with him. There is care, honesty with oneself. We're not deceiving ourselves in this relationship. In my previous relationship, I was deceiving myself by staying despite many aspects of love. It wasn't genuine. Through living together, I know a lot about him, even when he doesn't express certain parts of himself. I know when he's having a bad day, stressed, and I see through his reactions. Underneath it all, there's love. So, if you strip away the stress, problems, there's love there.

Speaker 1 [00:19:59] You froze. Are you there, [Name]? You froze. No, I can't see you. I see you, but you're frozen. Can you hear me? No.

Maria_Paula_5-10_High_Low-Median_Partner1 (part 2).mp4

Speaker 1 [00:00:04]: There also had to be a background.

Speaker 2 [00:00:09]: It doesn't matter if he comes automatically.

Speaker 1 [00:00:12]: Great father. Sorry about the internet. You were saying I would make it? From what you feel protected and this and other things.

Speaker 2 [00:00:28]: You asked me about how I know I am loved, and that was it. I said that I feel protected, and after some time with a lot of living together, we can perceive it in the details, in the subtleties of everyday life, in the way of speaking, the care, the affection, love in general. So it's like that, it's not just saying "I love you." We even have a joke where I say "I love you" and he says nothing more. And then I know he's there, in a good moment when he reaches out his hand. If he doesn't do anything, I already know something is wrong. So I think it's in the subtext. We don't even show much affection in public or on social media. We aren't really into that. It's more about the day-to-day, the routine, and the subtleties.

Speaker 1 [00:01:32]: I understand. And now about challenges and conflicts? What are your challenges? How do you deal with them and resolve these things?

Speaker 2 [00:01:46]: I think the fact that I'm studying [program] is very good because it gives us some tools, not just because I'm studying [program], but also because I have been in therapy for a long time and returned to therapy. So, the fact that we know each other very well, at least from my side, knowing myself well allows me to deal with things as a couple since I have been dealing with my individual issues for a while. So conflicts and issues, what was the word you used? Conflicts and difficulties and challenges, we put them on the table. We shed light on

them; we leave them to dialogue. So we try to understand how we feel about it. It's very common for me to notice something that bothers me, for example, a flaw of mine, which was one of the last discussions we had. I have a lot of difficulty hearing criticism from him, especially. So how do we resolve this? I tell him I don't know why, but I have trouble hearing your criticisms. And then we try together to understand why and how we will deal with it. So we really come up with strategies together. We don't fight in the heat of the moment with our nerves on edge. We present the problem: Look, we have this issue, we don't know how to solve it, how are we going to resolve it? How do you feel about this? This is how I feel, and for you, does it make sense? No, it doesn't. But for me, it comes from this place because of this and that. So we discuss it, and we find a solution together. Even if we need time to think about how we feel about it. I think that's how we do it.

Speaker 1 [00:04:29]: And there isn't a specific topic. It's always something that varies, depending on you, depending on him. You resolve it in groups, right?

Speaker 2 [00:04:40]: We generally start from the friction in the relationship, in the routine. Ah, this place here seems to be creating some friction. Why is that? And we notice it very easily because there's naturally a distancing. When we encounter some conflict, some challenge, we distance ourselves. It's natural, this individual retraction. And then it becomes very clear because we don't interact passively; we interact actively, constantly noticing these relationship nuances. So no, there isn't something that keeps coming back. We don't have problems that we sweep under the rug and keep returning to. No, we don't.

Speaker 1 [00:05:27]: Are these disagreements frequent or does it depend on each other's routine?

Speaker 2 [00:05:39]: There are some things that happen frequently, which are the nuances of routine. Things that one does one way and the other does another. So, in these small details, you can be sure that he should have done this and didn't. So these are the things of living together. And we have found our way to deal with them. Yes, I call it out because he lets a lot of things go, and I'm always hyper-focused on everything that needs to be done. So I ask for a lot of help. I say I have a very bossy personality, but he only works when I command. We joke about it. He says, as my aunt says, why don't you obey me? And we deal with it this way, laughing so it doesn't become heavy. So if I ask for something, I ask nicely so he doesn't feel bad about it. But there are various things of this operational, daily, and routine nature that always come up but are easily resolved. The more profound aspects related to his existence, his way of seeing the world, we discuss in depth. We create moments for these more philosophical journeys to understand how the other feels about issues we have no answer for. So we dive into it, discuss, and explain. He explains why it makes sense to him. He has a more mechanistic, utilitarian view, more goal-oriented. And I don't. I'm more about the journey and the path. I explain how it makes sense in my mind, and he tries. We look for this middle ground. He gives a little, I give a little, and we try to find a comfortable place for both of us. In this coexistence, I learn to deal more like him because I see it ends up being better or causing less suffering. And I think he has also learned from me, in comprehension and seeing the world. So it's about finding this point of reconciliation.

Speaker 1 [00:08:16]: Yes, that's it. I won't repeat the questions you already answered about how you resolve things. It's about asking in a way that he won't dislike, right?

Speaker 2 [00:08:34]: Practically speaking, trying not to cause more friction than already present. Speaking with care, trying to understand why he does things the way he does. But this is a tool I acquired very recently, explaining because he is very utilitarian. If it's like this, let's do it like this. For me, it's not like that. For me, there is a whole way to do it. I explain why it makes sense in my mind. He then says, "Okay, so you're not completely crazy. It makes sense." It's patience to try to make the other person see the form, to make the other understand how I see things.

Speaker 1 [00:09:22]: Patience and dialogue are the key.

Speaker 2 [00:09:24]: Yes, respecting each other.

Speaker 1 [00:09:29]: Would you say that this relationship is good for you? From the interview, I believe I know the answer, but can you answer if it's good and why?

Speaker 2 [00:09:40]: Yes, it's good because we are constantly building and improving it for us. Because if we just push it along without actively putting energy into it to deal with issues, daily frictions, and everything else, it wouldn't have the quality it has today. I think it's because we both are very committed to maintaining the relationship. If one of us gave up, it wouldn't work anymore. It's a joint effort.

Speaker 1 [00:10:19]: Do you believe your current relationship has changed anything in you?

Speaker 2 [00:10:24]: Certainly.

Speaker 1 [00:10:25]: Have you become calmer? It can be any change, physically or internally. What are these changes?

Speaker 2 [00:10:34]: I think the most obvious one for me is trying to take life with less neuroticism and more lightness. [Partner's Name] pulls me in this direction. He says, "Relax, take this thought away, go to that empty space I can access so easily. Let's spend energy, let's stay here, look at the sky." We often look at the stars and realize how small we are. And then we see how insignificant the problem is. We realize we are so tiny. So we decide to do it in the best way possible because we are so small. This gives a sense of calm. I am very neurotic, and he is very calm. So this tranquility is a significant change.

Speaker 1 [00:11:31]: Do you think anything has changed in him?

Speaker 2 [00:11:36]: Yes, he will tell you. I think the main change is that he realized that the world is not just made up of people who think like him. I'm putting it in my words; he will tell you differently. But my interpretation is that he realized the primary change is probably in his work values. He says my illness at work changed how he sees interpersonal relationships at work and how he works. So, caring for others in that environment could be done differently, with

conflict or aggression, but because he can access this calm place, he realizes that not everyone can. My illness taught him that his way of dealing with people has to be one that considers others. This change still reflects today in his work approach.

Speaker 1 [00:12:59]: Has [Partner's Name] been the same since the beginning of the relationship, or has he changed, comparing now and the beginning with you?

Speaker 2 [00:13:19]: Oh, I think many things in the routine we have found. Routine heavily influences long-term relationships, which is a place of much wear and tear. So this comes up a lot, and we started doing things because we are a partnership, a team. So there are many practical and small things he started doing that he didn't before. I can list several, like closing the kitchen sink's trash lid. These are very trivial things, but in a relationship, not accumulating them means he starts doing things differently. So practical, small routine things, yes. In terms of his personality, he has always been the same with me from the beginning. [redacted] So, in terms of essence, he hasn't changed much, if we can talk about essence. But practically, yes, he started doing many things that were important to me but weren't to him, which became important for both of us.

Speaker 1 [00:15:10]: So it was a positive change?

Speaker 2 [00:15:12]: Definitely.

Speaker 1 [00:15:15]: Do you feel safe? You said you feel protected with him.

Speaker 2 [00:15:21]: Yes, I feel safe. There was a moment when I felt very insecure, and I noticed it almost immediately. It was a difficulty we faced, and we dealt with it the same way. I presented the difficulty, explained why I felt the way I did, and we discussed it. Then I realized I was just extremely tired and mentally exhausted. When I rested, I saw it was just fatigue, not insecurity about the relationship but insecurity about not offering as much as I thought I should to the relationship, thus feeling insecure. So, there was only one moment of insecurity, which we talked about, and it didn't come up again.

Speaker 1 [00:16:19]: I was going to present a scale, but I can't show the screen now. I'll explain it: it's a scale from 1 to 9, where 1 is not true at all, and 9 is completely true. Can you rate according to two statements I'll tell you now? First, does [Partner's Name] really listen to you?

Speaker 2 [00:16:46]: Eh, eh, eh, eh. I can't say 100% true. From 1 to 9, what is the middle number?

Speaker 1 [00:16:56]: Five would be the middle.

Speaker 2 [00:17:00]: Five. I'll put a six. No, a seven. Because I talk a lot, and important things, when I call him and say, "I need you to listen to me," he listens. But in the rush of day-to-day life, some things get overlooked. So, not always.

Speaker 1 [00:17:27]: That's a good answer. Seven is very true. Nine is completely true, seven is very true.

Speaker 2 [00:17:33]: Yes, I think it's very true.

Speaker 1 [00:17:37]: And the second statement is: Does [Partner's Name] care about your needs? You can interpret needs in your own way, but if you want to discuss it...

Speaker 2 [00:17:48]: Let me think. Yes, he does care. Completely true, nine. Because even when it's a practical example from today, talking about organizational needs, Maslow's hierarchy, lower needs fulfill higher ones. When I was in doubt if they were being met. Lower needs, eight, higher needs, nine. Because I think even for needs that are entirely personal to me, related to self-fulfillment, once we are in this partnership, he supports them and cares about them, even if there is nothing he can do about them, even if it's entirely out of his control. For example, I bought a [language] course, and he won't pay for it; it came out of my savings, but he was always encouraging me when I was taking intensive classes. When I was in doubt about buying the course, he said, "It's important to you, right?" This has zero importance in his life; I'll do it while he's probably studying English, but it's my concern because it will benefit me. So, yes, there is this concern, even for higher-level needs, as Maslow would say.

Speaker 1 [00:19:32]: Great. Now, two questions about your sex life. If you're not comfortable, you can ask to skip them, but you're not obliged to answer. First, have you had sexual relations lately? No need for a detailed explanation.

Speaker 2 [00:19:54]: I think this is a challenging topic. It's not always brought up but sometimes it is. I compare a lot to the social standard of expected frequency and what works for us. It has to work for us as a couple, not for others. So it's a dilemma I still navigate. But yes, we have had sexual relations.

Speaker 1 [00:20:26]: We discussed the word "lately" because it's relative. Lately for you might be different for me. So it's a question for the individual to answer.

Speaker 2 [00:20:44]: I just wanted to say a guaranteed yes by law for that answer.

Speaker 1 [00:20:53]: God knows.

Speaker 2 [00:20:55]: He will have to say: No? Wait, let me think what "lately" means.

Speaker 1 [00:21:01]: Yes, it makes sense. And how satisfied are you with your sex life and why?

Speaker 2 [00:21:10]: I am satisfied but not fully because I still navigate this dilemma of how often I think I should have sexual relations and how often I actually do. This still causes me some distress. Thinking about others' expectations, even when we discuss it, he says it's fine for him, as long as it's fine for me, and it works for us. Still, there is this external influence that somewhat affects me, lowering my satisfaction. But looking at the relationship itself, I am fully

satisfied because in this aspect, he listens to me, which would be a perfect nine. We are always respecting, aligning expectations, and discussing desires, ambitions, and wants. So, yes.

Speaker 1 [00:22:05]: Would you like to add anything? My comment doesn't necessarily belong to the script but it's just my opinion that you are in a new city, and it's just the two of you. You live together; you study; you live far from your family. Fatigue affects a lot, right? Coupled with external expectations, it varies a lot. It's complicated.

Speaker 2 [00:22:32]: Yes, we can never fully meet these external expectations, so it's impossible. Exactly. It's also a personal issue of mine, the need for excellence. Fulfilling this normative causes some anxiety, but yes, all these factors influence, and we handle them well.

Speaker 1 [00:22:58]: Generally, I also had to present a screen, but I can explain it: How satisfied are you in your relationship overall, considering all the topics we discussed and other things you know about your relationship, from completely dissatisfied to completely satisfied, with the middle being neither satisfied nor dissatisfied. How would you rate it?

Speaker 2 [00:23:27]: I would say completely satisfied because if a problem arises, we mobilize to resolve it, to maintain this place of complete satisfaction, continuing to work actively on building a high-quality relationship. I loved the term "relationship quality."

Speaker 1 [00:23:48]: And the last question about this complete satisfaction answer: On a scale from 0 to 10, within satisfied, how satisfied are you? Like, is it 96?

Speaker 2 [00:24:07]: I would say 9.5 because there are things I would like to instill in the other person that are beyond my reach but would shine more in some aspects. But it's not up to me; it's about him. Not even...

Speaker 1 [00:24:23]: Not interior aspects?

Speaker 2 [00:24:27]: No, no physical aspects. But not, not. It's just things, aspects, like a small change in the structure of things. It's a wish of mine. For example, I would love for [Partner's Name] to read more. Because for his personal growth, it's a need for his self-fulfillment that I would like to see happening. But it's my wish, not his. He fulfills this in other ways that fully satisfy me. But it's a wish of mine, so it's like a small change in structure.

Speaker 1 [00:25:12]: This was the last question. Sorry for the interruptions during the interview with the internet issues and meeting exits.

Speaker 2 [00:25:21]: No problem.

Speaker 1 [00:25:21]: Thank you. I will send you a thank-you message on [Social Media] with a link to answer general questions about the research. This research is from [University] and a PhD student who adopted it for [Country], originally from a professor in the Philippines. You can answer these questions if you have any doubts or criticisms. If you have couples to suggest for the research, especially those with long relationships like 10-15 years, it would help a lot.

Speaker 2 [00:26:06]: They don't need to have a link with [University], right?

Speaker 1 [00:26:11]: No, any couple.

Speaker 2 [00:26:14]: Okay, I'll see if people are willing to participate.

Speaker 1 [00:26:19]: Thank you.

Speaker 2 [00:26:21]: It was a pleasure. I enjoyed participating.

Speaker 1 [00:26:24]: Great, I enjoyed your answers; they were very thoughtful.

Speaker 2 [00:26:29]: Great, I'll respond to everything as soon as we finish. My husband will clean this same space soon.

Speaker 1 [00:26:42]: I need 15 minutes to get some water.

Speaker 2 [00:26:46]: Okay, I'll tell him to call you. I'll send the link to him. Thanks, goodbye.